

Djokovic makes a Beijing comeback as Sabalenka discusses self-pressure

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-03 5 min read

Novak Djokovic protected his unbeaten record in Beijing with a demanding **comeback** at the China Open. The six-time champion defeated China's Bu Yunchaokete 4-6 7-6 (7-2) 6-2 to advance to the third round.

Bu took the opening set and challenged Djokovic again in the second. After giving back a break of serve, Djokovic needed a medical timeout. He accepted a time violation while trying to regain his breath between points and consulted a trainer.

The 39-year-old then took control of the tie-break. In tennis, a tie-break decides a set when the players are level in games. In the deciding set, he won four **consecutive** games and finished with a backhand winner after two hours and 52 minutes. He has never lost in Beijing in 31 matches.

Djokovic was scheduled to face either Alexander Zverev or Shang Juncheng on Saturday for a **quarter-final** place.

Aryna Sabalenka had a smoother opening match, beating Mexico's Renata Zarazua 6-1 6-3 in 63 minutes. She struck 11 **aces** and faced no break points. In tennis, **aces** are serves that land legally without the **receiver** touching the ball. A break point gives the **receiver** a chance to win the server's game.

The world number two was playing her first match since losing both the top **ranking** and her US Open crown to Elena Rybakina in September. Her latest titles came in March, when she won Indian Wells and Miami back-to-back, a pairing known as the Sunshine Double.

Sabalenka explained that demanding more from herself sometimes drives her forward but sometimes drains her energy. She said she was working hard to be easier on herself. Her next opponent is Czech player Nikola Bartunkova, who nearly beat her at the Berlin Open in June.

Word Treasure

comeback -- A recovery after falling behind in a contest.

consecutive -- Following one after another without a gap.

receiver -- The tennis player who tries to return a serve.

aces -- Legal serves that the receiving player does not touch.

ranking -- A player's position in an ordered list of players.

quarter-final -- A competition round before the semi-finals.

Background you need

A tie-break decides a tennis set when players are level in games.

A break point is a chance for the receiver to win the server's game.

The article calls winning Indian Wells and Miami back-to-back the Sunshine Double.

Break it down

Opens with Djokovic's result and unbeaten Beijing record.

Describes his second-set difficulties and deciding-set comeback.

Names his possible next opponents.

Reports Sabalenka's result and explains serving terms.

Adds her recent title history, comments on self-pressure and next opponent.

Why it matters

The article explains how Djokovic recovered after losing a set and how Sabalenka began her tournament successfully. Her comments also offer a player's view of the pressure created by demanding more from herself.

Test what you remember

1. Which round did Djokovic reach by beating Bu Yunchaokete?

- ☐ (A) The second round
- ☐ (B) The third round
- ☐ (C) The quarter-final
- ☐ (D) The first round

2. What happened while Djokovic was trying to regain his breath?

- ☐ (A) He accepted a time violation.
- ☐ (B) He skipped the deciding set.
- ☐ (C) He ended the match early.
- ☐ (D) He changed his next opponent.

3. How did Djokovic finish the match?

- ☐ (A) With a missed return
- ☐ (B) With a backhand winner
- ☐ (C) With an untouched serve
- ☐ (D) With a forehand winner

4. What does a break point give the receiver a chance to do?

- ☐ (A) Win the server's game
- ☐ (B) Finish the whole tournament
- ☐ (C) Replay the previous point
- ☐ (D) Choose the next server

5. Which tournaments did Sabalenka win for the Sunshine Double?

- ☐ (A) Indian Wells and Miami
- ☐ (B) Miami and Beijing
- ☐ (C) Indian Wells and Berlin
- ☐ (D) Berlin and Beijing

6. What is Sabalenka working hard to do?

- ☐ (A) Change the tennis scoring rules
- ☐ (B) Avoid entering the next round
- ☐ (C) Be easier on herself
- ☐ (D) Expect more from every opponent

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She said demanding more from herself sometimes drives her forward and sometimes drains her energy. She is working to be easier on herself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):